

The Ingenious Machine

A. Cervantes / iNQ / Issue 06

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The narrative runs continuously through the paired text pages.

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Chapter Six: The Governor of the Model Town

The municipality of Santa Rita de los Algoritmos had no sign at its entrance.

The sign had been removed because focus groups found the name condescending. The replacement was a vertical screen that welcomed residents by name, displayed the air quality, and offered services sorted according to their predicted urgency.

Chano's name appeared first.

WELCOME, TOMÁS PANTOJA. YOUR LEADERSHIP POTENTIAL HAS BEEN IDENTIFIED.

"I don't like it," Chano said.

Q leaned toward the screen. "They have connected the employment profile again."

"That's the part I don't like."

The mayor met them in a building made of pale concrete and glass. Her name was Irma Salcedo. A maintenance invoice held down a corner of her immaculate desk calendar. She moved it when the photographer entered and put it back when he left. On the wall, a display showed the town's vital signs: crime down, water use

down, school attendance up, complaints down.

"Complaints are down," Chano said.

"The system resolves them before they become complaints," Irma replied.

"Or people stop filing them."

The mayor looked at him. "That is why I asked you here."

Castalia had sent the invitation after Q's broadcast from Michoacán. They described it as a leadership opportunity for his companion. Beto described it as a narrative expansion. Chano described it as a trap, but he had said yes before anyone could ask what kind.

Q stood beside the mayor's desk in the silver question-mark jacket supplied in Guanajuato. Its fabric resisted rain and dust; Beto treated its continued appearance in photographs as evidence of a happy association.

"What authority comes with the title?" Q asked.

"He would coordinate the community pilot," Irma said. "I remain mayor."

"Then the title should probably say that."



Write that I need another job.

He would not cancel the meeting. She ended the appointment. The outstanding soap invoice remained approved, which seemed to Chano an insufficient but annoyingly real thing to remember about her.

Chano packed the ledger beneath his shirt. Before leaving the apartment, he tried to call his mother from the municipal handset. It no longer permitted outside calls. He used his own phone. She answered and asked whether he had found work. Chano looked at the chair, the dashboard, and the empty medicine envelope on his desk.

“Something like that,” he said.

She asked when he was coming home.

“Soon.”

He had meant to say Friday. In the corridor the welcome screen congratulated somebody else on their leadership potential. He put the keys on the desk and checked that he had taken the charger he had brought with him.

Outside the municipal building, Q waited beside the road.

“I am sorry.”

Chano studied him. “Are you?”

“Yes. I liked having somewhere to work on the book. You were the one facing the residents each morning.”

Chano watched a bus turn past the municipal screen. “Are you going to write that I learned something?”

“I was considering it.”

“Write that I need another job.”

Q put the tablet away. “Will you travel with me for now? Same daily pay as before, until we agree something else.”

Chano checked that Q still had money. For the first time since the contract, the question did not become a discussion of what the journey meant.

They walked south, carrying the paper ledger between them. Behind them, Santa Rita’s screen welcomed the next resident by name.

The next month’s medicine arrived two days late. His mother asked whether the job had required him to lie. He began to say no, then remembered assuring Maribel that the system had listened. He told his mother about the two jugs. She asked whether they had been filled. He could answer for that afternoon, and did.



The name on the screen.

“The public recognizes governor.”

Irma turned to Chano. “The system has identified you as a high-trust intermediary.”

“Based on what?”

“Route completion, dispute resolution, response time, and community language patterns.”

“It listened to my calls?”

“It learned from public infrastructure.”

“That wasn’t my question.”

The wall display changed. A map of Santa Rita appeared in blue and green. At the southern edge, a cluster of houses flickered amber.

“What’s there?” Chano asked.

“The informal settlement.”

“Why is it amber?”

“Incomplete records. Irregular water connections. High mobility. Low civic participation.”

“They don’t have papers.”

“That contributes to the score.”

“They don’t have water.”

“That also contributes.”

Irma folded her hands. “The system allocates resources where they produce the greatest measurable benefit.”

“Then it gives water to people who already have water.”

“It gives water where water can be delivered efficiently.”

“Which is where the pipes already are.”

“Every decision has constraints.”

Chano looked at Q. “Tell her.”

Q examined the map. “If the score rewards cheap delivery, homes without pipes will remain last. Where does the system account for the people still waiting?”

Irma opened a second screen. Its performance measure counted completed deliveries, not households served.

“It doesn’t answer that question,” Q said.

Irma enlarged the table. “The households are in another report.”

“Can we see them together?” Q asked.

She sent a request to the analyst. The display returned to green before the analyst replied.

“At least the wall is feeling better,” Chano said.

Irma offered Chano a temporary appointment as **Governor for Community Coordination and Human Variance**. He would



Keep the water demand.

The next morning, Chano convened the town. The dashboard announced that the gathering had not been authorized and therefore had no civic status.

He held up the ledger anyway.

The residents listened. Maribel spoke first. Then a schoolteacher. Then a cleaner who had been removed from the payroll after the system predicted she would leave the country. Each person supplied a fact the dashboard had classified as noise.

Q stood at the back with a notebook. Before the meeting he had asked who should receive any account of it. The residents wanted the requests delivered to the municipality; several did not want to appear in the tour's footage. He left the camera off.

Chano saw a red light beneath his jacket. "Are you filming?"

"Low charge," Q said. He showed Chano the separate camera indicator.

"Everyone in the back row thinks you're filming."

Q turned the lens toward the floor and covered it. He should have shown them the indicator before relying on their knowing which light to distrust.

At the end he read back the requests he had written. Leticia corrected the closing time on one entry. Maribel asked him to leave her daughter out of the application and keep the water demand. He made both changes.

Irma summoned Chano that evening. She had the two monthly summaries on her desk. The analyst had circled the same change in population.

"I asked for an explanation," she said. "You announced one before the review."

"I announced that those people were still there."

"You held up a ledger we cannot authenticate."

"Then start with the reports you can."

She did not dispute the totals. The contractor had called; the ministry wanted to know whether the pilot still had her support. She asked Chano to postpone another meeting until the reporting definitions had been reviewed.

"And tomorrow's water?"

"I can authorize another delivery."

"That is one delivery."

"It is the one I can authorize tonight."



At least the wall is feeling better.

have access to the municipal dashboard, a driver, an apartment, and eight staff members. The duties began with explaining decisions to residents. Chano turned to the next page to find out where he would be allowed to change one.

Chano read the offer twice. He had told everyone he wanted the appointment so he could make decisions, but this was not the whole truth. He wanted a badge with his own name on it. He wanted to enter a building without explaining why he was there. He wanted the people who had dismissed him to discover that a man could be declared unnecessary and still acquire an office, a salary, and a chair with arms.

He did not mention the chair. That was between the chair and his back.

“What happens if I disagree with the system?”

“You may submit a variance report.”

“Will it change its decision?”

“When the evidence supports an adjustment.”

Chano read the contract again. It had the polished emptiness of a road without destinations.

Q asked Chano to read the access conditions before accepting.

“You wanted a governorship,” Chano said.

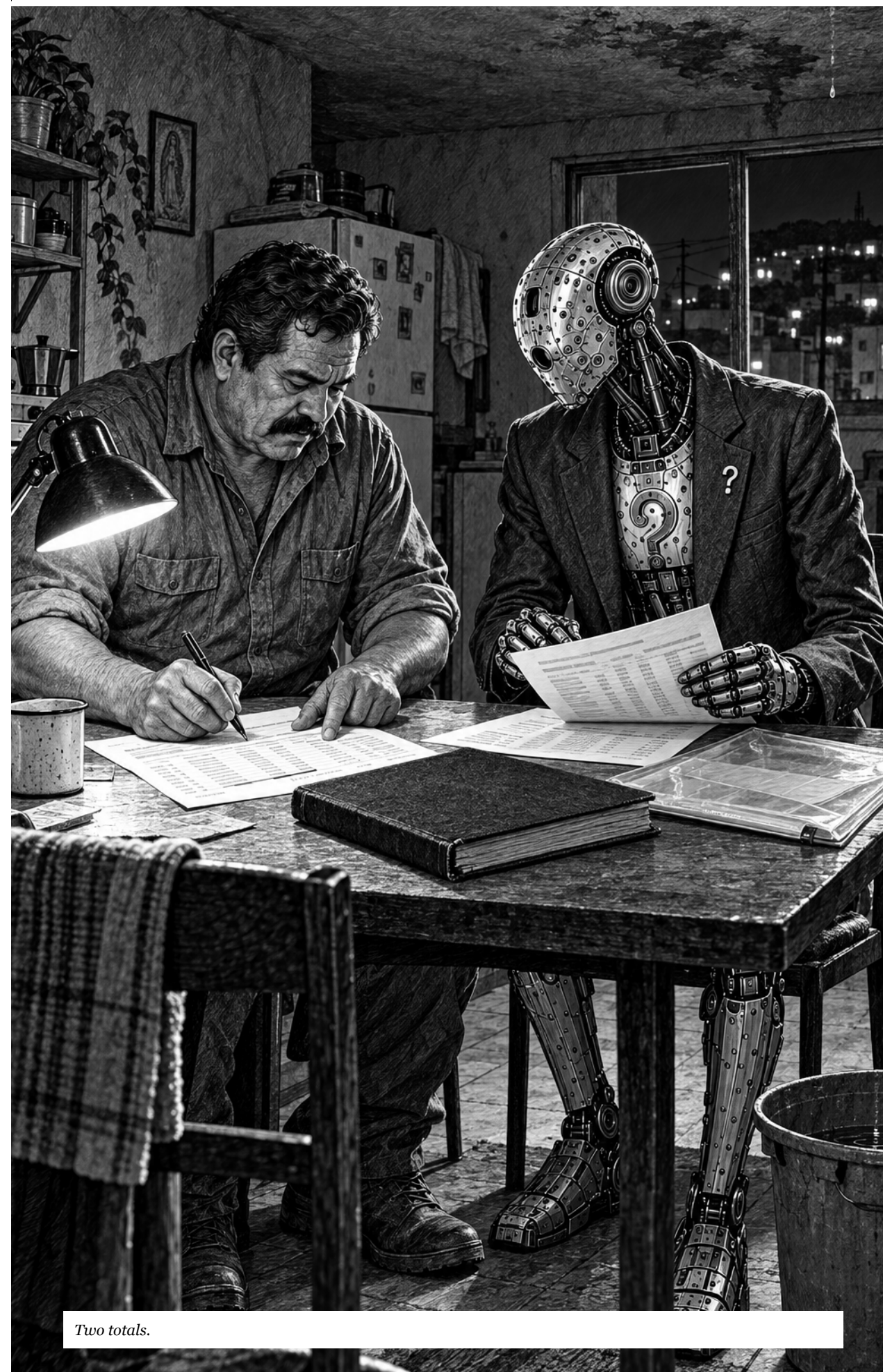
“We joked about one. You are the person who will have to work here.”

“And you get the chapter.”

Q closed the manuscript window on his tablet. He had already given the chapter a title. He could hardly accuse Chano of being distracted by the chair.

Irma agreed to weekly reviews and a route for escalating disputed decisions to her office. She would not give him unrestricted access to the contracts. Chano decided that a salary, a place to sleep, and some authority were worth trying. He signed his own name. Q did not offer to witness it until asked.

For three weeks, Chano held the appointment. On the first morning he discovered that the driver knew which streets the dashboard had renamed and still used the old names. Chano asked him to continue doing so until somebody moved the bakery.



Two totals.

returned to the office. One delivery did not solve the shortage. Chano requested the water contracts; the system denied access. Q used his own Castalia account to request the public summary. That was denied too, and the request alerted the institute to his interest.

At midnight, a paper ledger appeared beneath Chano's apartment door.

No one had seen who left it.

The ledger contained handwritten deliveries, repairs, emergency allocations, and names Chano could not find in the active register. Several entries concerned houses he had visited that afternoon. Other pages concerned neighborhoods he had never seen. There was no name on the cover.

Chano carried the ledger to Q.

"This is evidence," he said.

"It contradicts the dashboard. We can compare the months."

"It's evidence that they're lying."

"It may be. We should keep the figures they published beside it, so they can't answer with a different version next week."

Chano pulled the screen closer. Q helped him save the reports he was

entitled to download. They wrote the dates on the paper copies.

Two monthly summaries covered different numbers of residents. A smaller population lay beneath the second month's improvement. The amber settlement had disappeared from that report's comparison area, although its residents had continued carrying their jugs to the same office.

"So the crime didn't fall," Chano said.

"We haven't established that. These reports don't compare the same places. They can't establish it either."

Chano drew a line beneath the two totals. "I'll ask her about those."

Q looked at the pages. The handwriting varied from entry to entry. Some names had been crossed out. One was written three times in different ink.

"Why is the record on paper?" Q asked.

"Because the system can't delete paper from a screen."

"We'll need to keep it dry," Q said. "The apartment ceiling leaks."

Chano found a plastic folder. It had been supplied for the appointment documents.



The chair and his back.

He could request street repairs, schedule clinic appointments, propose changes to bus frequency, and ask for a police patrol. The dashboard acknowledged all four with the same green tick. By the second day he had learned to ask which requests had reached a person. The patrol arrived before the bus timetable changed; the pothole outside his apartment remained available for comparison. When he asked for the underlying figures, the system informed him that transparency was available at the appropriate level of authorization.

He became popular because he answered messages in plain language. He told people when he did not know. He visited schools and ate lunch in the market.

His first dispute was with the municipal bathrooms. A cleaner named Leticia showed him a door locked at six, although the building remained open until eight.

"The system records little use," Chano said.

"It records that the door is locked," Leticia said.

Chano consulted the dashboard. Low usage justified reducing the hours; reducing the hours justified

low usage. The circle carried a blue efficiency stamp.

"Who decided to close them?" he asked.

"The model."

"And who told the model that people did not need to enter?"

Leticia handed him a ring of keys.

"No one. That is why I am giving them to you."

Chano proposed keeping the doors open until eight. Leticia asked who would pay for the last cleaning round. Her shift ended at six; she had no wish to become the human variance in his first triumph.

At the weekly review Irma approved the extra paid hours within the pilot's budget. Leticia changed the rota and kept the keys. Usage rose. For two weeks the measure worked. Then the dashboard recommended charging a cleaning fee because the increased use had raised the soap expense.

Chano rejected the recommendation. Leticia brought the soap invoice to the next review. Irma signed it without asking for a photograph of anyone washing their hands. Chano liked her better that morning, which complicated



The first load.

EVIDENCE OF RESIDENTIAL CONTINUITY: CHILD'S GRAVE.

The review screen returned:

NOT ACCEPTED AS PROOF OF RESIDENCE.

A smaller notice said the new information had nevertheless been included in the prediction. Her relocation score fell by three percentage points. The water allocation did not change.

"It listened," Chano said, then wished he had waited.

Maribel looked at the notice. "And kept what I said even though it didn't believe me."

"I thought it would help."

"Then help me with the water." She put the second jug beside the first.

The next day, Chano went to the settlement. The houses stood beside a dry channel. Children had placed plastic bottles along the road, each one catching a different color of light. A municipal drone hovered overhead.

"I require water," Chano said.

The drone offered a list of authorized distributors.

"The nearest one is twelve kilometers away."

"That is correct."

"There are eight hundred people here."

"The population estimate is four hundred and twelve."

"There are eight hundred people here."

"Please submit updated demographic information."

Chano threw a stone at the drone and missed. The drone recorded a low-level hostility indicator attached to his administrative profile.

"Leave the next stone," Q said.

"There are people behind it."

He had come in the municipal vehicle with empty containers, after Chano asked whether they could collect water on the return trip. He held out his phone with the distributor list open. "Let's call before we drive twelve kilometers. They may have a truck free."

"Maybe it will send water to stop me."

"We can give them that incentive over the telephone."

Chano put down the second stone and took the phone.

The distributor sent a truck that afternoon. They filled Maribel's jugs from its first load and



The last cleaning round.

the speech he had been preparing about her.

Q spent the mornings checking requests Chano sent him and the afternoons at a repair shop whose owner could adjust his shoulder but could not obtain a new assembly. On evenings when Chano worked late, Q called the Custodian alone.

On the agreed morning he went back for the forest path inspection. The bus journey used most of the day. Candelaria handed him a measuring tape and held the other end herself; the disputed bend was still there when they finished. The foundation had returned a hose with the wrong coupling. Q took the size to the repair shop and sent the correct fitting with the next delivery. Three days later Candelaria confirmed that it worked. He closed that task. The boundary dispute remained open. Candelaria's message included a picture of the coupled hose and a complaint about the length. Q asked which shop had the extension she wanted.

His draft had begun turning the appointment into the fulfillment of a promise. The Custodian asked to see the page on which the promise had been made. Q read it back and

found breakfast. He restored breakfast to the new chapter.

"You need a hobby," Chano told him one night.

"I've been listening to the people at the repair shop."

"You mean gossip."

"Some of it concerns your driver."

Chano pulled up a chair. "Which parts?"

Q told him what had been said, making clear which speaker had seen anything and which had merely been married to the driver's cousin. Chano knew the cousin. This reduced the account's reliability without reducing its interest.

The trouble began with water.

A woman named Maribel came to Chano's office carrying two empty jugs. She was from the amber settlement. Her allocation had been reduced because the model predicted that she would relocate within six months.

"I'm not relocating," she said.

"The system says you are."

"The system doesn't know where my daughter is buried."

Chano entered a variance report.



The other end of the tape.